



Housing under platform capitalism: the contentious regulation of short-term rentals in European cities

by Thomas Aguilera, Francesca Artioli, and Claire Colomb, 2025, 466 pp., £25 (pbk.), ISBN: 9780520418080

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BOOK REVIEW

Housing under platform capitalism: the contentious regulation of short-term rentals in European cities, by Thomas Aguilera, Francesca Artioli, and Claire Colomb, 2025, 466 pp., £25 (pbk.), ISBN: 9780520418080

Several themes have dominated housing studies over the past two decades. This includes the housing boom preceding the 2008 financial crisis (Reinhart & Rogoff, 2008), after which many people lost their homes and were forced into the rental market (Mian & Sufi, 2015). Housing prices subsequently rose above their pre-crisis peaks (Bank for International Settlements, n.d.). As a result, many renters found themselves trapped, unable to transition into homeownership (Haughwout *et al.*, 2024; Waldron, 2023). While the scarcity of land and housing has played a significant role in driving up housing prices, short-term rentals (STRs) mediated by platforms such as Airbnb have become especially prominent in recent years, closely linked to tourism and mobility.

Academic literature has increasingly focused on the effects of Airbnb-mediated STRs on housing prices (Eliasson & Ragnarsson, 2018; Garcia-López *et al.*, 2020) and renters (Mermet, 2022; Mixa & Loftsdóttir, 2025). This body of work includes both comparative analyses and case studies. A new book, *Housing Under Platform Capitalism: The Contentious Regulation of Short-Term Rentals in European Cities*, makes a timely and substantial contribution to contemporary debates. It undertakes systematic cross-regional comparisons of laws and regulations in a dozen major cities, providing the field with a much-needed and ambitious study.

The book consists of three parts. Part I contextualizes STRs within the frameworks of tourism and assetization, and summarizes prior research on STR regulation. Part II presents the heart of the book, comparing regulatory regimes across 12 tourist-intensive European cities (Amsterdam, Barcelona, Berlin, Brussels, Lisbon, London, Madrid, Milan, Paris, Prague, Rome, and Vienna), and introduces a quantitative Intensity of Regulation Index (IRI) (p. 100) to measure the degree to which local governments intervene in STR markets.

The IRI enables the authors to categorize these regimes into three broad ‘worlds’. World 1 represents a laissez-faire approach, where the emphasis is on taxation rather than limiting the scope of STRs. World 2 includes cities where local governments initiate tighter regulations, and World 3 is where local governments additionally pursue stronger interventions, such as those influenced by active grassroots mobilizations. This framework is innovative and will likely be applied in future academic analyses of the STR market.

Part III sheds light on the struggles of implementing the above-mentioned goals within multi-level governance. Despite using the systematic IRI, the authors caution that there is no direct and straightforward correlation between the variables and their impact on regulation (p. 101). One could argue that this caveat is an understatement. This lack of neat linearity underscores the book’s recognition of the subject’s complexity.

The variety among cities is striking. Pre-existing institutional arrangements, levels of tourism, regional economic conditions, grassroots mobilizations, and homeownership patterns all shape regulatory responses. These factors are particularly relevant to gentrified areas, which in turn affect the power that business groups and political clienteles have in shaping laws and regulations to their advantage. Among the book’s most valuable

insights is its demonstration that the relationship between STRs, tourism, and gentrification (with commercial interests often substantial) is multifaceted. While platform-mediated STRs operate transnationally on a similar scale, the degree of rent extraction and restrictions varies according to welfare/housing regimes, socio-economic contexts, and shifting political climates.

The book further shows that local STR regulations are embedded within national, regional, and local provisions, and may also be influenced by European court and legal decisions. This multi-layered framework, discussed in detail in the latter chapters, underscores the complexity of regulation. A vivid example is Barcelona's 2017 plan to achieve zero growth of STRs. Since regional laws do not distinguish between professional and permanent STRs and the occasional rental in one's own residence, those who already held licences benefited from rising property values with permits, while other residents were restricted from earning income needed to remain in their apartments (pp. 153–154). This paradox illustrates how well-intentioned regulatory measures can inadvertently create unequal benefits and perpetuate market segmentation.

To clarify these dynamics, the book provides a comprehensive literature review of the history and progress of STRs, as well as associated laws and regulations, including health and safety standards and the maximum ratio of STRs to permanent residences. It reveals how platforms attempt to standardize regulation across jurisdictions, frequently offering self-regulations, while resisting unwanted laws. Part of that campaign has frequently been to frame the STR market as a tool for ordinary citizens to rent out their homes; a narrative that becomes more difficult to promote as large corporations capture an ever-greater share of the market (pp. 52–56).

The book highlights the diverse range of participants, including social movements, local officials seeking to reconcile affordable housing with the economic realities of STRs, those defending specific neighborhoods and downtown areas, and the hotel industry. It also explores the creation of additional income for both individual residents and large corporations that own extensive STR portfolios. Within this contest, governments strive to strike a balance between embracing new technologies and maintaining control within their jurisdiction. The authors consolidate this multi-level governance perspective by stating that the regulation of platform and STR activities is the result of power relations and negotiations between various actors with different interests and at different scales, which can take diverse forms that require explanation (p. 79).

This interaction, as the book's description demonstrates, is by no means clear-cut. An example is the notion that the political parties in each area tend to act similarly, depending on whether they are left-wing or right-wing (pp. 125–129). While there are correlations in most cities, the authors point out that, for instance, right-wing parties in some boroughs of London have, in some cases, advocated (unsuccessfully) for more regulation (p. 198). While European cities have increasingly begun synchronizing their efforts regarding regulation and enforcement (p. 289), the process has been, and likely will remain, complex - much like a strategic chess match, where the rules are clear but the outcomes remain unpredictable.

By aiming to be comprehensive, the discussion at times resembles nested matrices, making navigation difficult. The depth of the book constitutes, in some sense, also its weakness. The difficulty of tying so much information together helps explain why the subject has been underresearched until now. While this work provides a detailed introduction, a clearer summary of the main concepts and results at its beginning would have aided readers in navigating its many facets.

Nevertheless, this book is ideal for researchers who focus on housing issues in general, as STRs significantly affect housing and rental prices, not only in downtown and

gentrified areas, but also increasingly in other regions. With this book, researchers, particularly those examining the impact of tourism and mobility on the housing and rental market, can apply the systematic methods outlined to evaluate differences in comparative and case studies more comprehensively. It stands as a crucial contribution to understanding how layered legal and regulatory frameworks shape the STR market, and how this process, in turn, reshapes housing affordability and long-term rental markets across regions.

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